



THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

By then, most of our athletes had failed to clinch medals and the pressure was mounting up and I knew that I could not miss out on the opportunity of clinching India's second individual medal — 44 years after Khashaba Jadhav won a bronze in wrestling in Helsinki.

But throughout the tournament, my team ensured that we did not discuss anything about winning or losing. My parents, my sister and a few dear friends were with me around that time and I spent a lot of time with them, just talking about everything else except my performance. That approach helped me handle the trickiest of the situations. To keep myself calm, I listened to a lot of music and my playlist would revolve around the numbers by Gipsy Kings, Sting, A.R. Rahman and Michael Jackson. That would keep me in my zone.

And that mental toughness reflected in my game during the bronze medal fixture. I knew the match was going to test my mental strength. In the first set, I was unable to have control in my playing wrist and lost. In the second set, I shifted gears and was able to bounce back and win, with two breaks.

But in the third set, I found myself several break points down early. Fernando and I traded breaks and I protected my injured wrist by making shorter rallies.

My aggressive tennis mounted the pressure on Fernando, and when his final passing shot down match point sailed over my head and beyond the baseline, my hands went up in the air. And the tears rolling down my cheek were not only for the triumph, but also for the pain I endured to win a medal for my country. It indeed was a proud moment! As I returned to our base, the entire Indian contingent cheered for me. I met Ali at the locker room after the game, and only then did it sink in that I have actually fulfilled my dreams. He congratulated me, hugged me and being one of his biggest fans, I couldn't have asked for more. It was an emotional moment.

As told to Shayan Acharya